

10 / SAFETY & PROTECTION

When something feels wrong.

You do not need to prove abuse before asking for help. These observations can have different causes; a checklist cannot establish a diagnosis or determine that abuse occurred.

Immediate danger

Call 911. Do not delay urgent help to fill in a form or organise alternative care.

Concern about abuse or neglect

Call the Ontario Seniors Safety Line: 1-866-299-1011. It supports older adults and people concerned about them, 24/7.

Listen and document safely

Record dates, what you saw or heard, and who was present. Use the person's own words where possible. Do not confront someone if doing so may increase danger.

Protect the person's choices

Ask privately what they want where it is safe to do so. A helpline can help plan next steps, including safe support if the person they fear also provides care.

A concern in a care home

Contact the relevant regulator or care-home reporting channel promptly. Reporting duties can apply; use current official guidance, not a promise that every report can be anonymous.

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Physical signs

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Unexplained bruises, cuts, burns, or welts
- ☐ Bruises in unusual locations: upper arms, torso, face, or inner thighs
- ☐ Injuries at different stages of healing at the same time
- ☐ An injury is inconsistently or implausibly explained
- ☐ Signs of being restrained: rope marks or bruising on wrists or ankles
- ☐ Head injuries or patches of hair loss
- ☐ Broken bones, especially repeated fractures
- ☐ Bite marks or signs of rough handling
- ☐ The caregiver insists on being present during all medical exams
- ☐ There are delays in seeking medical care for injuries
- ☐ The person flinches, pulls away, or seems afraid of touch
- ☐ The caregiver speaks for the person and prevents them from speaking
- ☐ Medical records show frequent emergency visits for unexplained accidents
- ☐ The person appears heavily sedated or unusually drowsy without clear medical cause
- ☐ The person's account of how an injury happened changes from one telling to the next

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Emotional & behavioural signs

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Withdrawal, fearfulness, or unusual anxiety that is new or increasing
- ☐ Sudden changes in mood, personality, or behaviour
- ☐ Reluctance to speak freely, especially when a specific person is present
- ☐ Expressions of shame, worthlessness, or hopelessness
- ☐ Reports of being yelled at, threatened, humiliated, or controlled
- ☐ Reluctance to discuss personal, financial, or daily life matters
- ☐ Disinterest in activities, hobbies, or people they previously enjoyed
- ☐ Avoidance of eye contact when a particular person is nearby
- ☐ Excessive deference or agreement with a specific caregiver or person
- ☐ Marked anxiety when the caregiver is mentioned or enters the room
- ☐ Statements such as 'I deserve this' or 'I am a burden to everyone'
- ☐ Sleep disturbances, nightmares, or new fearfulness at night
- ☐ Sudden withdrawal from contact with family or friends
- ☐ Refusal of visits from people they previously enjoyed seeing
- ☐ Signs of depression: flat affect, tearfulness, prolonged withdrawal
- ☐ New confusion or disorientation without a clear medical explanation

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Financial signs

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Unexplained or large withdrawals from bank accounts
- ☐ Transfers of money to unfamiliar individuals or accounts
- ☐ Bills unpaid or services disconnected despite adequate income or savings
- ☐ Sudden or unexplained changes to a will, trust, or beneficiary designations
- ☐ A new power of attorney signed under unclear or pressured circumstances
- ☐ Missing cash, jewellery, valuables, or personal possessions
- ☐ Credit cards used without the person's knowledge or consent
- ☐ Unfamiliar signatures on financial, legal, or property documents
- ☐ New acquaintances with unusual or intrusive interest in the person's finances
- ☐ A caregiver or family member controls all mail, phone access, and financial documents
- ☐ The person is unaware of their own financial situation or account balances
- ☐ Unexplained loans or financial commitments the person cannot explain
- ☐ Sudden purchase of items the person did not want or did not choose
- ☐ Property titles or vehicles transferred without a clear or voluntary reason
- ☐ The person is asked to sign documents they cannot read or properly understand

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Neglect & unmet needs

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Poor hygiene, unwashed clothing, or persistent body odour
- ☐ Malnutrition or significant unexplained weight loss
- ☐ Dehydration without a clear medical explanation
- ☐ Medications not being given, tracked, or managed correctly
- ☐ Pressure sores or bedsores from being left in one position too long
- ☐ Untreated medical conditions, wounds, or infections
- ☐ Living space that is unsafe, cold, dirty, or in serious disrepair
- ☐ Insufficient food in the home for the person's needs
- ☐ Necessary aids missing: glasses, hearing aids, dentures, or mobility devices
- ☐ The caregiver is consistently unavailable, absent, or unreachable when needed
- ☐ The caregiver openly expresses resentment, frustration, or hostility toward the person
- ☐ The caregiver appears impaired, unwell, or unable to provide appropriate care
- ☐ The person is left alone for long periods without check-ins or emergency access
- ☐ Medical appointments are being consistently missed or cancelled
- ☐ The home is excessively cluttered or presents a clear fall or fire hazard
- ☐ The person has no access to outside contact, visitors, or community

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Fraud, scams & digital abuse

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Unsolicited calls about prizes, debts, utility problems, or government benefits
- ☐ Gifts, gift cards, or money sent to people the person has never met in person
- ☐ A new romantic partner met online who is requesting money or personal information
- ☐ Unexplained purchases, subscriptions, or donations the person cannot explain
- ☐ Pressure from callers to act immediately and to keep this secret
- ☐ Callers claiming to be from a government agency demanding urgent payment
- ☐ An unusually large volume of charitable solicitation mail
- ☐ The person appears confused, distressed, or secretive after phone calls or online sessions
- ☐ Accounts accessed from unfamiliar devices, locations, or at unusual times
- ☐ Social media activity or messages that seem out of character
- ☐ Pressure to pay for products, services, or fees using gift cards
- ☐ The person has shared passwords, PINs, or financial details with online contacts

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Concerns in a care setting

Note what changed and when. A sign is a reason to seek advice, not proof by itself.

- ☐ Staff are dismissive, impatient, rough, or openly disrespectful toward residents
- ☐ Family visits are discouraged, restricted, or made difficult by staff
- ☐ The person seems afraid to speak in front of certain staff members
- ☐ Unexplained injuries, bruises, or changes in the person's physical condition
- ☐ The person appears unusually sedated without a clear medical reason
- ☐ Staff cannot explain injuries or changes in the resident's condition
- ☐ Personal belongings, money, or valuables are missing or unaccounted for
- ☐ The resident is frequently left in soiled clothing for extended periods
- ☐ The resident's requests, complaints, or needs are consistently ignored
- ☐ The facility is visibly understaffed during visits
- ☐ Complaints raised with management are dismissed or not investigated
- ☐ The resident asks to leave, expresses fear of the facility, or fear of specific staff
- ☐ Other residents or visitors have raised similar concerns
- ☐ There are visible signs of unsanitary conditions or poor infection control

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A clear record. A safer next step.

Keep this page somewhere safe. If a device or account may be monitored, use a safer way to seek support.

Date, time and place

What I observed / what the person said

Immediate support sought / who was contacted

Advice received and next steps / follow-up date

For suspected financial loss, contact the financial institution through a trusted number and ask for urgent fraud support. A lawyer or the Seniors Safety Line can help you consider further steps.